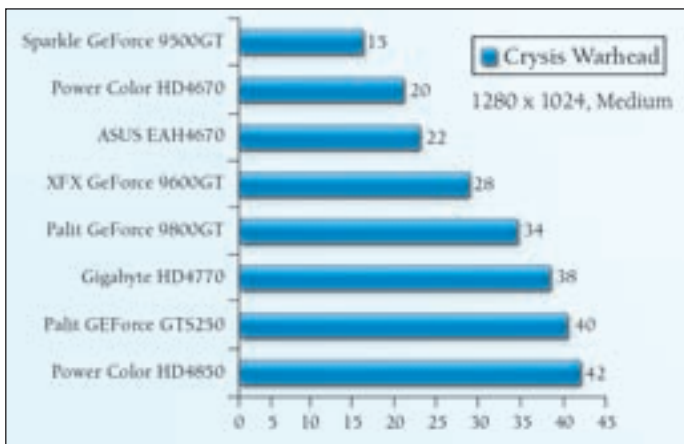


Dynamic shadows

In older games such as Quake 3, shadows used to be preset for each character and map, but with dynamic shadows, the shadow created by any object or character in a game gives a more natural look and changes according to changes in the environment

Graphic Card Test



from vendors like Palit and PowerColor and ZOTAC. The 9600GTs, 9800GTs and even a GTS250, can now be purchased within this price bracket. The 9600GTs are based on the G94 GPU, whereas the 9800GTs and the GTS250s GPU codename is the G92.

From AMD, in this category, we have HD4670s based on the RV730 GPU, a single HD4850 and an HD4840 with the RV770 GPU, and HD4770s with the RV740 GPU. ATI's HD4770 is the world's first graphics card based on a 40nm GPU (RV740).

Features

Since these cards aren't really meant to fit into HTPC cabinets they tend to have larger form factors. Power connects are an important factor here. There were some 9600GTs and 9800GTs that require 6-pin PCIe power connects, while others such as the ZOTAC 9600GT ECO 1GB and the ZOTAC 9800GT ECO 512 MB, XFX GeForce 9600GT 512 MB didn't need an

external power connect.

Since this category is meant to attract gamers, another feature that's important is support for SLI for NVIDIA cards and CrossFire for AMD cards. The only card that did not support CrossFire in this category was the Power Color HD4670 1GB.

A game bundled with these cards would have been a good offer, but unfortunately it's not the case, as mentioned earlier none of the cards we received came bundled with any games.

Cooling solutions play another important role here as you will be stressing the GPU when playing games, so keeping it cool is a high priority. In this category, passively cooled cards are not really that good an option. XFX has used a cooling solution on the Radeon HD4830, which looks similar to the NVIDIA GTX series of cards, and does quite well.

Connects on the card are something that you would need to watch out for, especially if you plan to use this rig as an HTPC and don't really care about keeping it in a tiny cabinet. For that reason, an HDMI port would be an added bonus. The XFX GeForce 9600GT, Palit



PowerColor HD 4850 512MB

GeForce 9600GT, Galaxy GeForce 9800GT 512MB, Palit GeForce 9800GT 512MB, ASUS EAH4670 1GB, Palit GTS250 and Power Color HD4850 are the graphic cards in this category that come with HDMI ports.

The ZOTAC GeForce 9600GT Eco 512MB comes with a CD of 3D Mark Vantage, whereas the XFX GeForce 9600GT 512MB came with a Key for the same software. The XFX cards in this category also come with the gamers door tag; the same as mentioned in the previous category.

Performance

Out of all these cards, the MSI HD4670 reached the highest temperature, touching 71 degrees Celsius under load, while the coolest here was

Palit GeForce GTS 250

